

Louis Armstrong: West End Blues 🎵

Louis Armstrong and His Hot Five, 1928

West End Blues is one of the most famous recordings in the history of jazz for the following reasons: 1) Armstrong's introduction showed how dazzling his skills as a trumpeter were; 2) he laid the groundwork for jazz soloists to be considered true artists, the same as musicians in other styles of music and; 3) the recording introduced Earl Hines as the first real jazz pianist, who was Armstrong's equal in creative musical thought.

Outline of *West End Blues*:

- ▣ Trumpet introduction by Armstrong
- ▣ Ensemble plays with Armstrong heard above all
- ▣ Trombone solo
- ▣ Call and response: clarinet solo alternates with Armstrong scat-singing
- ▣ Piano solo by Earl Hines, playing with a trumpet-like attack
- ▣ Armstrong solos: holds a high B-flat for almost four measures
- ▣ Earl Hines' piano enters to join Armstrong for ending.
- ▣ The number is closed by a deft woodblock click by the drummer

Louis Armstrong: Potato Head Blues 📢

Louis Armstrong and His Hot Seven, 1927

With the addition of a tuba and drum set, the Hot Five became the Hot Seven for a series of recordings. Louis Armstrong was the among first to record improvised solos during what jazz musicians call *breaks*. A break is a pause in the ongoing rhythm of a composition-as happens several times during the clarinet solo.

A related musical practice is stop-time in which the instruments hit typically just one beat per measure.

Potato Head Blues provides an excellent example of how Armstrong's natural sense of rhythm made his solos swing. Not strictly speaking a "blues", the chord structure is a 32-bar form. (Excercise: Count the number of breaks you hear!)

Outline of *Potato Head Blues*:

- ▣ Ensemble
- ▣ Trumpet solo with banjo accompaniment
- ▣ Clarinet solo in high register with banjo accompaniment, includes several breaks
- ▣ Banjo break
- ▣ Trumpet solo with Armstrong accompanied by the band in stop-time
- ▣ Ensemble